



### Change is the name of the game:

The emergence of the Women's Premier League, the revival of the 'A' system, and a focus on the Under-19s have given the women's T20 game a much-needed fillip. PTI

robust talent identification programme. All this augurs well for India in the T20 World Cup year, the last edition before cricket makes its Olympic debut at Los Angeles 2028.

Returning to the men's side, India would hope to go all the way in the World Test Championship this time, having lost two back-to-back finals. On both occasions, it was India's batting that succumbed to probing spells of fast bowling. The Test team is in flux, but a new selection panel gives Rohit a chance for a makeover. He needs a more assertive and proactive approach, both on and off the field. Rohit needs to make tough calls if need be.

A change of guard is imminent. Ajinkya Rahane, who was vice captain

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on the West Indies tour in 2023, was dropped for the South Africa and England (first two) Tests, while Cheteshwar Pujara, India's No. 3 for a long time, has not been picked in the squad since scoring only 14 and 27 in the World Test Championship final against Australia in June last year. If logic had the final say, India perhaps wouldn't turn back to the duo, signalling the end of an era in more ways than one.

But again, when has sport been completely rational? So, to say the fans have had a final glimpse of their batting heroes would still be premature. Theirs will be big shoes to

fill, and it is not like the younger players have knocked the door down for batting numbers 3 and 5. But they do deserve a longer rope, keeping in mind the five Tests against England at home, followed by the five away Tests in Australia towards the end of 2024.

While captain Rohit and coach Rahul Dravid's tone pretty much conveys that the next few months may not be about set patterns but about trying out a few new players, it is becoming increasingly clear that 2024 will be the year a line is drawn in the sand. The time to put the wheels of change into motion is now.